

100 Days of Linux - Day 005

Title: Removing Files and Directories (rm & rmdir)

Today's Goal

Learn how to safely delete files and empty directories using **rm** and **rmdir**.

Why This Matters

Developers and data engineers constantly clean up temporary files, logs, test data, and unused folders. Knowing how to remove them safely is essential.

Commands of the Day

rm

Syntax: rm filename

Explanation: Removes a file.

Example: rm notes.txt

rmdir

Syntax: rmdir directory_name

Explanation: Removes an **empty** directory only.

Example: rmdir day05

Beginner Lesson

You have learned to create folders and files. Today you'll learn to remove them. Always verify what you're deleting with **ls** before using **rm**. Remember that **rmdir** only works on empty directories.

Practice Questions

1. Create a file named temp.txt and then delete it.
2. Create an empty directory named old_folder and remove it.
3. Create a directory named test_dir, create a file named demo.txt inside it, then try removing test_dir using rmdir. Observe what happens.
4. List the contents of your current directory after completing the previous tasks.
5. Display your current working directory.

Hints

Use touch before rm, and mkdir before rmdir. Check directory contents with ls.

Mini Challenge

Create a folder named cleanup. Inside it create three files: a.txt, b.txt, and c.txt. Delete all three files, then remove the empty cleanup directory.

Common Mistakes

Using rmdir on a directory that still contains files. Empty the directory first.

Did You Know?

Unlike the Windows Recycle Bin, files removed with rm are usually not easy to recover.

Pro Tip

Always run ls before rm to confirm you're deleting the correct file.

Answer Key (Instructor Only)

Q1: touch temp.txt && rm temp.txt

Q2: mkdir old_folder && rmdir old_folder

Q3: mkdir test_dir && cd test_dir && touch demo.txt && cd .. && rmdir test_dir (fails because it's not empty)

Q4: ls

Q5: pwd

Homework

Practice creating and deleting five different files and three empty directories.

Next Day Preview

Tomorrow you'll learn how to copy files and directories using the cp command.